ES 1092 Collecting Nature: Exploration of Scientific Collection Winter 2026

Professor: Dr. Brittany Slabach (Dr. B, she/her) **Email:** bslabach@coa.edu

Office: Davis Center (south campus), 2nd floor – come visit!

Drop-in Hours: Wednesday 9:30 - 10:30 AM and Thursdays 2:30 – 4PM, or by appointment. Drop-in hours will take place in CHE 101, unless otherwise announced. I try to make myself available whenever I have free time. If the above times do not work for you, please send me an email with times you are available, and we'll make it work! I am more than happy to meet via zoom, but please email me to schedule a time to do so. Feel free to stop by my office anytime and say hi if I'm there.

Class time and location

Lecture: Museum classroom, Tuesday & Friday from 10:35 AM – 12:00 PM
Lab: CHE 101, Friday from 1:00 – 4:00 PM
Classes will be a mixture of lecture, discussion, and activities. Labs will be used for field trips to visit museums and collections; and to introduce, and practice, specimen preparation and care.

Course Objectives: This course is designed to introduce, and explore, the history and care of scientific collections. We will explore the science and art of scientific collecting, preparing, and caring for specimens (plant and animal). We will discuss the history of scientific collections, and collection practices, and consider their role and value. We will visit natural history museums, their collections, and the curators that care for them, gaining additional perspectives. Finally, we will practice the art of specimen preparation and care, learning different preparation and cataloging techniques. Throughout the term we will continue to ask what is – and should be – the role of collections.

Required Readings – There isn't one book we will use for this course. Instead, we will be reading a variety of book chapters and articles. I will provide all readings in the Google Classroom and a hard copy of all books (if available) will be put on a 4-hour reserve in the library. Below is a list of some of the books we will be using.

- *Cabinets of Curiosities* by Patrick Mauries
- *Life on display: revolutionizing U.S. Museum of science and natural history in the twentieth century* by Karen A Rader and Victoria E. M. Cain
- *Herbarium: The quest to preserve and classify the world's plant* by Barbara M. Thiers

Time Commitment
Students are expected to complete a minimum of 150 hours for this course, equal to 15 hours each week of active academic engagement (i.e., classes, readings, preparation for discussion, fieldtrips, and assignments). Your academic engagements should approximately follow this outline:

Hours	Commitment
60	Class time
40	Active reading of assigned material
10	Curatorial practices – 5 hours must be completed by week 5!
20	Writing assignments
20	Final project
Total	150

Guiding Policies & Expectations
Attendance and Participation: I expect you to attend and be active participants in our class. This means coming to class prepared, having completed the required readings, asking, and answering questions, taking notes and being present. I always prefer an open dialogue, so please ask questions! If I don't know the answer to a question, I will get back to you. If it seems that a question might divert class from immediate goals, I may ask you to come talk to me separately or to be sure we revisit the topic at another time but keep asking! And please do follow up – I don't forget on purpose; I just get distracted.

As this is an interactive course, attendance is important to your learning experience and success. Therefore, absences will be reflected in your participation grade. But illness and life happen! I completely understand this. I'm here to support your learning and success. Please communicate with me when you can. *If you are not feeling well and contagious (e.g., have a fever), do not come to class.* Be sure to get notes from a classmate and we can set up a time to meet and review any missed materials. If absences become common, we will meet to discuss your goals and options moving forward.

There will be group work throughout the semester both in and outside of the classroom. Collaboration is a required part of life, and it can be a truly rewarding experience. It can also be frustrating. To be an effective collaborator it is important to communicate clearly, set expectations – and agree on them – and to be respectful. It is expected that you will treat each other with respect, listen to each other's perspectives and work through any issues together. Remember, we are a team and a community. Everyone has valuable input and perspectives!

Field Trips: I have organized several field trips over the course of the term. These experiences are meant for us to explore natural history collections, the curators that care for them, and the exhibits they produce, live and in person! These are important and integral portions to this class, *and attendance on these trips is required*. A few of these field trips are local and will occur during our regular class/lab time. The other field trip is a three day, two night, trip to visit Harvard's Museum of Comparative Zoology and the Harvard Herbarium. During this trip we will meet with several curators and get a behind the scenes tour of the collections. The following day we will visit the

museum and tour the exhibit! We will depart on the afternoon of January 29th (no later than 2 pm) and return the evening of Saturday, January 31st. I realize an afternoon departure means you may need to miss class. *If this is the case, please talk to me ASAP.* I am aware of the additional time commitment required of this trip and have canceled a class and lab to ensure this experience doesn't overload anyone. I will provide draft itineraries, and we'll discuss more details in class.

Communication: Please don't hesitate to email me or stop by with any questions or to just chat. I try to respond to all correspondence at least once a day. But if I haven't responded within 24 hours, email me again. I do typically respond to emails on weekends, but responses may be delayed more than 24 hours given field work and life. I will be corresponding with the class via email, so please be sure to check correspondence regularly.

Use of Electronics in Class: Cell phone use is not permitted once class has begun, unless it is to take pictures of specimens or exhibits. If you would like to use any devices to record classroom lecture or discussions, this must be approved prior to use. Some discussions may not be recorded due to privacy reasons. Laptops may be used to take notes, but if there is multi-tasking or perusing the interwebs that occurs, this privilege will be removed.

Statement on plagiarism and academic honesty: By enrolling in an academic institution, a student is subscribing to common standards of academic honesty. Any cheating, plagiarism, falsifying or fabricating of data is a breach of such standards. A student must make it their responsibility to not use words or works of others without proper acknowledgment. Plagiarism is unacceptable and evidence of such activity is reported to the academic dean or their designee. Two violations of academic integrity are grounds for dismissal from the college. Students should request in-class discussions of such questions when complex issues of ethical scholarship arise. *Use of AI, of any sort, to complete assignments is plagiarism and will result in a zero for that assignment.* If you have any questions about the use of AI, please come and talk to me!

***Accommodations*:** I am happy to work with anyone who requires special accommodation to thrive in this class. Please reach out to me to discuss any accommodation needs.

A note on deadlines: There is a 48-grace period for each of your essays, meaning you may submit each of your essays within 48 hours of the due date and there is no penalty associated. If they are submitted after this 48-hr grace period, there will be late penalties applied to your grades. Your final project is a **hard** deadline, meaning the poster and written pieces must be submitted at the stated due date. Any submissions after this will receive a late penalty. No late work will be accepted after March 14th, unless you have previously discussed this with Dr. B.

Grading & Assessments

Written Essay – 45% (15% first essay; 30% final reflection)

Throughout the term, I want us to reflect on what we are reading, discussing, and experiencing. In doing this I want us to think about why we collect; what we value and why; how have collection practices biased what we value and what we know about the natural world; and what is – and should be – the role of collection in today's world. There will be two essays for you to explore

these topics in an individualized way throughout the term. Each essay will have prompts, but there will be flexibility in topics and your approach. Individual prompts and requirements for each essay can be found in the Google Classroom. Writing is an iterative process and to help practice this, I'm happy to review drafts at any time! If you are unhappy with your grade, you may edit and resubmit your *first* essay within two weeks of getting your initial grade back. Your new grade will replace the initial grade, if you choose to resubmit.

Curatorial Practice – 15%
Caring for a specimen doesn't end after preparation, instead it is a long-term relationship. We will practice specimen care throughout the term by assisting with different projects involving our collections. You are required to complete 10 hours outside of class time working with our collections. *Five of these hours must occur prior to the beginning of week five!* Note, if you are a museum work study student, these are separate hours from your work-study hours!

Projects include standardizing dry and wet specimen labels; standardizing protocols; and freezer organization and clean out! Our standard curatorial hours will be Monday and Wednesday from 9 AM -12 PM, and Thursday from 1 - 4 PM in CHE 101. You will be asked to sign up in advance (one hour time slots). If these times/days do not work for you, you must discuss with Dr. B so we can be sure you get your hours in! You may also conduct your curatorial hours in the Herbarium. To arrange that please contact Jill Weber at jweber@coa.edu.

Final Project – 25% (15% proposal; 10% infographic)
For your final project, I want you to prepare two different forms of scientific communication to teach a broad audience about the role, or use, of collections in today's world. You will be working in groups to create a social media proposal which will include a written portion. You will also create a graphic in the form of a poster that you will present to the class. A draft submission of the proposal is due week 7! Additional information can be found in the final project handout.

Attendance & Participation – 15%
Class attendance is required. You are expected to be present at, and actively participate in, all class meetings. I understand that participation can be somewhat subjective, therefore, this portion of your grade will be determined by the following: completing the pre-course survey; attending all required meetings; being punctual to all meetings; and being actively engaged. Active engagement means you are not surfing the interwebs, texting/emailing others, having side conversations, or conducting any other work that does not pertain to the course. Instead, you are being an active listener, asking and/or answering questions, and participating in discussions with your peers about subject matter. If you need to miss for some reason, let me know as soon as possible! If you have four or more unexcused absences will not receive a passing grade for this course.

***Title IX/Sexual Misconduct Reporting*:** As a Responsible Employee who is committed to creating an environment where every member of our community can thrive, I want to let you know that I am a Mandatory Reporter. What that means is that I am required to report any instances of sexual misconduct, including sexual harassment, non-consensual sexual intercourse, nonconsensual sexual contact, sexual exploitation, intimate partner violence, stalking, and related retaliation that I am aware of to the Title IX Coordinator. So, if you share information with me about any incidents

that implicate the Sexual Misconduct or Anti-Harassment Policies, I am required to report all information to the Title IX Coordinator to make sure you have information about support resources and complaint resolution options. My report does not initiate the complaint process, and you are in control over how you choose to engage with our Title IX Coordinator, Puranjot Kaur. If you or someone you know has experienced sexual misconduct, including sexual harassment, I encourage you to share this information directly with our Title IX Coordinator (pkaur@coa.edu) or one of the individuals who has been designated as a confidential resource on campus. For more information regarding Title IX, our institutional policy, and to access helpful resources, visit COA's Title IX website: coa.edu/human-resources/title-ix.

Course Schedule – Winter 2026

Topics and schedule are subject to change at instructor's whim, class needs or in response to college requirements. All readings will be made available on the Google Classroom.

Week	Date	Day	Topic	Reading Due
1	6-Jan	Tuesday	Introduction to the course – What is a collection?	Syllabus; Podcast
	9-Jan	Friday	Collection Care and Legality What is the value of collections?	Grinnell 1910, Holmes et al. 2016
2	13-Jan	Tuesday	Scientific Thinking and Cabinets of Curiosity	Farber 2000; Cabinets of Curiosity; Herbaria
	16-Jan	Friday	LC Bates Museum Visit	New England Travel Article; Simpson 1942
3	20-Jan	Tuesday	Colonial Collections: The Famous, and Hidden, Collectors	Darwin, Wallace, and Bates: *Collector to be assigned!*
	23-Jan	Friday	Entomology Preparations	TBD
4	27-Jan	Tuesday	The "New" World Collections	Akeley Expeditions; Sweeny chapter; *Essay 1 due*
	30-Jan	Friday	MCZ Trip	MCZ Readings and Podcast
5	3-Feb	Tuesday	The New Museum	Life on Display Chapter
	6-Feb	Friday	*No Class or Lab due to MCZ trip*	
6	10-Feb	Tuesday	Bias in Collections	Cooper et al. 2019; Smithsonian Magazine
	13-Feb	Friday	UMO Herbarium Visit	TBD
7	17-Feb	Tuesday	Evolution of Collections	Johnson et al. 2023
	20-Feb	Friday	Term Project Meetings	*Term Project Draft Proposal Due*
8	24-Feb	Tuesday	Genetics and Collections	TBD
	27-Feb	Friday	Collecting as Conservation	Hornaday Bison Group Articles
9	3-Mar	Tuesday	Collecting as Conservation Continued	Larson 2002; *Essay 2 due*
	5-Mar	Friday	The Feather Lab	Podcast
10	10-Mar	Tuesday	Who should own collections?	WSJ 2024; A Dino Name Sue; Kekatos and Vilcarino 2024
	13-Mar	Friday	*Infographic round table!*	

Laboratory Schedule – Our schedule is subject to change based on weather, availability of speakers, specimen availability, and student interest! Field trips days are in blue.

Date	Topic
9-Jan	Carrie Graham, Dorr Museum and Collections Tour & Jill Webber, COA Herbarium Tour
16-Jan	LC Bates Field Trip – *Depart at 10:35 AM from Whale Skull*
23-Jan	Specimen Preparation Lab 1 – Study Skins
30-Jan	Museum of Comparative Zoology and Harvard Herbarium, Harvard University ***Departure on Thursday, Jan. 29th return Saturday, Jan. 31st***
6-Feb	No Lab due to MCZ trip
13-Feb	UMO Herbarium Visit – *Depart at 10:35 AM from Whale Skull*
20-Feb	Specimen Preparation Lab 2 – Skeletal Prep
27-Feb	Prepping Giants – Field trip to Dan DenDanto's workshop – *Depart at 1PM from the Whale Skull*
6-Mar	Specimen Preparation Lab 3 – Wet Specimens
13-Mar	Specimen Preparation Open Lab – Term Project Due by 4pm!